Moradabad and Rampur seats were changed. Meerut saw a dizzy blur of the turnstiles. First, Supreme Court advocate Bhanu Pratap Singh came in as a Dalit face. Then, after the BJP announced actor Arun 'Lord Ram' Govil and a Meerut native to boot, the SP lost its nerve. It now entrusted the seat to Atul Pradhan, a loyalist of SP chief Akhilesh Yadav and a Gujjar who had proved his mettle by defeating Sangeet Som of the BJP in the 2022 assembly poll from Sardhana. However, a day later, Akhilesh changed his mind again and opted for ex-mayor Sunita Verma, a Dalit and former BSP member—a cementing of the Dalit-Muslim vote was clearly on his mind. Similarly, ex-MLA Amarpal Sharma replaced Manoj Chaudhary in Baghpat.

In Moradabad, sitting MP S.T. Hasan has had to forfeit his seat for ex-MLA Ruchi Veera. In Rampur, the SP chief chose Maulana Mohibullah Nadvi, an imam of the mosque near Parliament House complex in Delhi. But this is Azam Khan's fief, and though the leader stands disqualified, his supporters are apparently none too happy with an outside candidate being foisted on them. To add to the confusion, the BSP has forged itself as a "double-edged sword", as a rival puts it. Mayawati has put up Muslim candidates in minority-dominated seats such as Rampur, Moradabad and Saharanpur, which may cut into INDIA votes. But she has also fielded OBC and forward caste candidates in polarised seats such as Kairana and Muzaffarnagar, which could dent the NDA.

Pilibhit is seeing a more personality-based churn after the BJP replaced sitting MP Varun Gandhi—whose saffron loyalties were beginning to look ambiguous—with Congress import and state PWD minister Jitin Prasada. The consternation among Varun's supporters is apparently so deep that the SP candidate here, Bhagwat Gangwar, claims they are "helping him". Prasada, though, is unperturbed. "No matter

# THE YOUNG AND RESTLESS

**Gen-next leaders are taking decisive steps in many constituencies this election. Will they make the cut?**

**Lending some fresh energy to the 2024 western UP poll campaign is a crop of young leaders. They include Chandrashekhar Azad of the Aazad Samaj Party (ASP), Iqra Hasan of the Samajwadi Party (SP) and Chandan Chauhan of the Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD). Azad, president of the ASP and the Bhim Army, finds himself in a tough four-cornered fight in Nagina, after the SP, following initial talks, decided to keep him out of the alliance. The 37-year-old Dalit leader's poll symbol, the kettle, has also become a key element in his poll strategy, with people flocking to offer donations on the campaign trail. In the past three months, the Saharanpur-born Azad has made Nagina his second home. A division in the Opposition vote (both BSP and SP are in the race) could mar his chances even as Muslims and Dalits together make up over 50 per cent of the votes in the reserved constituency. Talking to INDIA TODAY, Azad says it's the people who are the engine of his campaign. "*Yeh chunav mujhe janata lada rahi hai*...they aren't just giving me money to**



RAJWANT RAWAT

## CHARTING A NEW COURSE

### BHARATIYA JANATA PARTY

- Highlight 'double engine' sarkar and Yogi's tough-on-crime 'bulldozer baba' image
- Getting Jayant Chaudhary's RLD into NDA helps in two ways–gets the Jat vote in the sugar belt and quells farmer unease in the region
- Leaving the opposition camp in disarray by poaching strong local leaders from rival parties

### TEAM INDIA

- The Samajwadi Party and Congress are hoping to consolidate the Muslim-Yadav vote. Gandhis arriving late could affect Congress fortunes
- Raising local issues, keeping election low-key to avoid any polarisation in the vote
- Small public meetings, chaupals part of the strategy

### BAHUJAN SAMAJ PARTY

- Allotting party tickets according to caste combination in constituency has disrupted the momentum of other parties
- Dalit-Muslim faces could hurt the SP, forward-caste candidates can dent NDA's chances
- BSP chief Mayawati still X factor in UP contests